KOCHI HAS WELCOMED THE WATER METRO. DAILY RIDERSHIP CROSSED THE 10,000 MARK IN LESS THAN A WEEK

The timely completion of the project was a challenge for the team. The Water Metro team had to wait two years to get a green signal from Coastal Regulation Zone Authority to build jetties even after submitting a detailed plan. Again, operational challenges and then the Covid delayed execution. "I'm happy that we have finally made a breakthrough and become the star attraction of Kochi. We have also tailored local transport facilities to suit the commuters," added Behera.

State tourism minister Mohammed Riyas says he is sure that the Water Metro would be a big boost tourism prospects in and around Kochi. "No country in Asia has linked remote islands and in such a long stretch. The Kerala government is planning to introduce a similar facility in Kuttanad connecting Alappuzha," Riyas told INDIA TODAY.

The Metro authorities are also seeking the support of private players in sharing the cost of building new boats and jetties to reduce the project coast. Many corporates have already come forward to support the initiative as it gives them great visibility. The island people too have welcomed the new service as it has reduced their travel time by half. Vypeen resident Sheela Joy says, "We are really happy that the Water Metro has become a reality. It's already very popular and, in fact, they should extend timings and operate from 5 a.m. to 11 p.m. It gives a classic feel of travelling in the backwaters."

The extension of Water Metro services to other parts of Kerala, especially the central and southern parts, could become a gamechanger in eco-friendly and cost-effective commuting. When fully operational, experts say it could reduce greenhouse gas emissions by at least 16,500 tonnes annually. ■



NIKHIL TIWARI

WRESTLERS' PROTEST

FIGHT TO THE FINISH

By Prashant Srivastava

The untimely rains in the national capital have failed to douse the anger of the country's top wrestlers who have been staging a most dramatic protest at Jantar Mantar since April 23. In many ways, it's the fight of their lives. Even as the Delhi Police on April 28—following the Supreme Court's intervention—registered two FIRs of sexual harassment against Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) president and six-time Lok Sabha MP Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh, the grapplers say they won't give up till he is arrested. A Bharatiya Janata Party MP from Uttar Pradesh's Kaiserganj parliamentary seat, Brij Bhushan is accused of sexually harassing seven women wrestlers, including a minor.

Since May 1, the protest site has seen a quick makeover given the change in Delhi's weather. Mattresses on which the protesters and their supporters used to sleep have now been put away. A makeshift cover of tarpaulin sheets has come up to shield those who continue to spend night after night at Jantar Mantar. Even as the number of supporters has dwindled, owing both to the rain and appeals made to them to return home, many continue